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Easy Weeknight Dinner Recipes

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Picky-Eater Dinner Ideas That the Whole Table Will Eat

By the Trillion Man Outreach kitchen crew Updated October 8, 2026

If dinner at your house comes with negotiations, you are in very large company. Picky eating is common in kids, and the goal is not to win a standoff but to make meals calmer and give children plenty of chances to get comfortable with new foods. Here are strategies and dinners that help.

Five strategies that lower the pressure

Serve it deconstructed.
Keep foods separate so kids can build their own plate. Tacos, baked potatoes and pasta bars work well.

Keep one safe food on the table.
Bread, rice, fruit or plain pasta means nobody leaves hungry.

Offer, do not push.
Place new foods on the table without pressure. Kids often need many exposures before they accept something.

Let them help.
Stirring, sprinkling and naming a dish makes children more curious about eating it.

Eat together when you can,
and let them see you enjoying the food.

Dinners that are easy to customize

Baked potato bar

Microwave or bake potatoes and set out cheese, black beans, broccoli, sour cream and salsa. Each person tops their own. Our
microwave sweet potato with black beans
works the same way.

Taco night

Salsa chicken, seasoned beans or ground meat, tortillas and a row of toppings. See
slow cooker dinners
for an easy base. Cook ground meat to 160 F.

Pasta bar

Plain pasta, marinara, butter and parmesan, plus optional white beans, spinach or chopped vegetables on the side. Our pantry tomato pasta can be served this way.

Fried rice with mix-ins

Cook plain rice and eggs, then let everyone add peas, carrots or scallions. It is also a smart leftover chicken rescue.

Quesadilla night

Cheese is the foundation. Add beans, chicken or finely chopped spinach for those willing to try it.

Small tricks that help

Cut food into fun shapes or serve dips. Many kids like to dunk.

Pair a new food with a favorite one on the same plate.

Use small portions so a new food feels less overwhelming.

Avoid labeling kids as picky. Say "you're learning to like it."

When to ask a professional

If your child eats a very limited range of foods, is losing weight, gags frequently or seems distressed around meals, talk to your pediatrician. Occasional pickiness is normal, but persistent concerns deserve a professional opinion.

Plan it in

Build one flexible dinner into your weekly meal plan. The Cheap Dinner Vault also includes picky-eater notes with simple swaps on every dinner.

Let us take dinner off your plate

The Rescue Kit picks dinner by how tired you are. The Cheap Dinner Vault shows what each dinner costs.

Get the Rescue Kit

Get the Cheap Dinner Vault

Questions, answered

How many times does a child need to try a food before liking it?

There is no exact number, but it can take many low-pressure exposures. Keep offering without forcing.

Should I make a separate meal for a picky eater?

Most parents have better luck serving one meal with a safe food included, rather than cooking a separate dinner.

Helpful outside resource

For practical, age-appropriate nutrition guidance for children, visit
USDA MyPlate's nutrition guidance for kids
.

Explore every dinner guide

Keep building your weeknight plan with these related guides. Each one covers a different part of getting dinner on the table.

5-Ingredient Dinners: Short Grocery List, Real Dinner

Simple dinners with five ingredients or fewer.

Cheap Family Dinners With the Cost Per Serving

Learn to estimate cost per serving and stretch a grocery budget.

Easy Dinner Ideas for When You Have No Energy

Low-effort ideas for exhausted nights.

Easy Sheet-Pan Dinners

One-pan dinner formulas, roasting tips and easy combinations.

Freezer Meals for Busy Weeknights

Make-ahead dinner ideas, freezing tips and safe thawing guidance.

Leftover Chicken Recipes

Turn leftover chicken into several easy dinners.

Pantry Staples List for Budget Cooking

Build a practical pantry for affordable meals and less food waste.

Slow Cooker Dinners for Busy Families

Hands-off slow cooker meals, timing tips and safe food handling.

Weekly Meal Plan for Busy Families

A seven-night dinner plan and shopping list.